



Acupuncture with Point Location Content Outline

Effective September 1, 2026

Note to Candidate: This document serves as a guide to assist in examination preparation for candidates who have met NCBAHM™ eligibility requirements. Below is the content outline for the Acupuncture with Point Location examination.

Please note: In regards to Clean Needle Technique (CNT), the Acupuncture with Point Location module focuses on actual needling and its emergencies (e.g., needle angle and depth) in comparison to the Biomedicine module which focuses on universal precautions and emergency situations.

Domain I. Acupuncture Point Location (15% of Exam)

1. Identify points on images.
2. Identify points according to cun measurement and anatomical landmarks.

Domain II. Safety for Acupuncture Practice (15% of Exam)

1. Describe risks and benefits of acupuncture, moxibustion, and adjunctive therapies.
2. Recognize risk factors for individual patients (e.g., pregnancy, pacemaker, blood thinners, diabetes, hypoglycemia).
3. Recognize and manage adverse events (e.g., burns, pneumothorax, bruising, hemorrhage, needle shock, stuck needle).
4. Comply with Clean Needle Technique (CNT) standards and procedures.
5. Apply infection control procedures to acupuncture practice (e.g., CDC's Standard Precautions, OSHA standards).

Domain III. Treatment Planning (40% of Exam)

A. Selection of treatment methods (25%)

1. Establish a treatment plan with appropriate treatment methods (e.g., acupuncture, cupping, moxibustion, combination of modalities).

2. Adjust the treatment plan for specific patient populations (e.g., pediatrics, geriatrics, pregnancy, disabilities, history of trauma).
 3. Evaluate patient's progress and modify the plan based on treatment response.
 4. Discuss expectations for treatment with the patient (e.g., body sensations).
- B. Acupuncture point selection (15%)
1. Identify actions and indications of acupuncture points.
 2. Perform acupuncture point selection based on pattern differentiation, symptoms, and actions and indications of points.
 3. Select points according to the following theories:
 - a. *Channel (Jing Luo)*
 - b. *Five Elements (Wu Xing)* (e.g., imbalances, excess-deficiencies, mother/son)
 - c. *Organ (Zang Fu)*
 - d. *Eight Principles (Ba Gang)*
 - e. Point combinations (e.g., four gates)
 - f. Tender points (*Ashi*)
 - g. Myofascial trigger points
 - h. Motor points
 4. Select points according to the following point categories:
 - a. *Five Transporting (Shu)/Antique* points (e.g., *Jing-Well, Ying-Spring, Shu-Stream, Jing-River, He-Sea*)
 - b. Extra points¹
 - c. *Eight Influential* points
 - d. *Eight Confluent* points
 - e. *Four Seas* points
 - f. *Front-Mu (Alarm)* points
 - g. *Back-Shu (Associated)* points
 - h. *Source (Yuan)* and *Connecting (Luo)* points
 - i. Tonification and/or Sedation points

¹ See Appendix A. Extra Points.

- j. *Five Elements* points (e.g., wood, fire, water)
- k. *Xi-Cleft* points
- 5. Select points according to the following acupuncture concepts:
 - a. Auriculotherapy
 - b. Local, adjacent, distal
 - c. Mirroring (e.g., elbow-for-knee, right-for-left, front-for-back)
 - d. Scalp acupuncture

Domain IV. Treatment Techniques (30% of Exam)

A. Acupuncture (15%)

- 1. Identify indications, precautions and contraindications for acupuncture (e.g., pregnancy, organ damage, inflamed or non-intact skin).
- 2. Apply appropriate patient positioning and draping procedures.
- 3. Select needles to achieve desired treatment goals (e.g., length, gauge, filiform, or other types of needles).
- 4. Apply appropriate needling techniques:
 - a. Insertion (e.g., angle, depth, stretching skin)
 - b. Manipulation (e.g., arrival of Qi, reinforcing, reducing, lifting, thrusting)
 - c. Retention time
 - d. Removal (e.g., order, speed, pressure)
- 5. Apply myofascial trigger point (MTrP) techniques (e.g., local twitch response (LTR), dry needling, motor points).
- 6. Adjust needling technique based on patient's response (e.g., stimulation method, intensity, needle retention time).

B. Moxibustion (5%)

- 1. Identify indications, precautions and contraindications for moxibustion.
- 2. Select the appropriate moxibustion technique (e.g., direct, indirect, warming needle).
- 3. Adjust the moxibustion technique based on patient's response.



C. Adjunctive therapies (10%)

1. Identify indications, precautions and contraindications for adjunctive therapies.
2. Select the appropriate adjunctive technique:
 - a. Bloodletting
 - b. Cupping
 - c. Ear seeds, balls, magnets
 - d. Acupuncture with electrical stimulation
 - e. Guasha
 - f. Tuina
 - g. Acupressure
 - h. Heat application (e.g., heat lamp)
3. Modify the adjunctive technique based on patient's response.



Appendix A. Extra Points

The exam will focus on but may not be exclusively limited to the list below.

Anmian

Bafeng

Baichongwo

Bailao

Baxie

Bitong

Dannangxue

Dingchuan

Erbai

Erjian

Heding

Huatuojiayi

Jianqian/Jianneiling

Lanweixue

Luozen

Pigen

Shiqizhuixue/Shiqizhuixia

Shixuan

Sifeng

Sishencong

Taiyang

Tituo

Xiyan/Neixiyan

Yaotongxue

Yaoyan

Yintang

Yuyao

Zigong



Acupuncture with Point Location Examination Suggested Bibliography

The Content Outline is the primary resource for studying for this examination. The purpose of this Bibliography is only to provide the candidate with suggested resources to utilize in preparation for the examination. Candidates should feel free to consider other resources that cover the material in the Content Outline.

There is no single text recommended by NCBAHM™. All NCBAHM™ examination modules reflect practice in the United States as determined by the most recent job analysis.

NCBAHM™'s item writers and examination development committee members frequently use the following texts as resources; however, the sources used are not limited to the books listed here. The NCBAHM™ does not endorse any third-party study/preparation guide.

Primary Sources

Cheng, Xinnong. (Ed.). *Chinese Acupuncture and Moxibustion*. 4th ed. Beijing: Foreign Languages Press, 2019.

Council of Colleges of Acupuncture and Oriental Medicine. *Clean Needle Technique Manual Best Practices for Acupuncture Needle Safety and Related Procedures*. 7th ed. Council of Colleges of Acupuncture and Oriental Medicine, 2020.
[\[https://www.ccahm.org/ccaom/CNT_Manual.asp \(CCAHM Website\)\]](https://www.ccahm.org/ccaom/CNT_Manual.asp)

Deadman, Peter, Mazin Al-Khafaji, Keven Baker. *A Manual of Acupuncture*. 2nd ed. East Sussex, England: Journal of Chinese Medicine Publications, 2007.

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Secondary Sources

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Bisio, Tom. *A Tooth from the Tiger's Mouth: How to Treat Your Injuries with Powerful Healing Secrets of the Great Chinese Warrior*. New York: Fireside Books, 2004.

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Ting Liang, and Bob Flaws. Trns. *A Handbook of Traditional Chinese Gynecology*. 3rd ed. Boulder, CO: Blue Poppy Press, 1987.

Xu, Xiangcai. *Chinese Tui Na Massage: The Essential Guide to Treating Injuries, Improving Health & Balancing Qi*. Boston, MA: YMAA Publication Center, 2002.